Instead, Vance traveled to China in August. India—and the region more broadly—was on the agenda for discussion. Ahead of the trip, Brzezinski said he wanted Washington to get from "tacit … parallelism" to "greater coordination" with Beijing on issues like "preventing Soviet dominance of the South Asian subcontinent or the Indian Ocean."[135] This interest meant a desire for Sino-Indian rapprochement. Vance encouragingly told his Chinese counterpart Huang Hua, who welcomed Desai's "genuine nonalignment," that Indian officials wanted to "reduce their excessive reliance" on Moscow. He also assured Chinese policymakers of the American intent to maintain its presence in the region. In this regard, Vance stressed that, before any Indian Ocean arms limitation agreement with the Soviets, the US would complete work on its base at Diego Garcia—which Deng had previously encouraged.[136]

Pluses and Minuses

As far as Brzezinski was concerned, the administration's China policy remained unsatisfactory and left Beijing with the impression that it was a lower priority. In a six-month report card, he gave it a C+. India policy, however, got a B, with relations "on the upswing."[137]

And they were. In September, Carter announced that he would undertake a multination tour that would include India—but not, commentators noted, Pakistan.[138] The administration wanted to ensure that nothing rocked the boat with India ahead of that trip. It would, for instance, abstain on a Pakistani-proposed UN resolution for a South Asia nuclear-free zone. The White House knew that India opposed any such proposal that excluded China, and would be upset with a US vote in favor.[139]

The announcement of Carter's trip was the occasion for a debate among the China and India hands on the NSC staff. Lamenting that China policy was in the "doldrums," Oksenberg said that Carter visiting India, but not China or East Asia more broadly, was "of no help."[140] In response, and to criticize how overboard Washington went for Beijing, Thornton cited Huang declining an opportunity to meet with Carter on the UN General Assembly sidelines. American presidents and secretaries of state, he said, "haul themselves off to Peking to do homage" while the Chinese foreign minister would not even deign to postpone a flight to meet with the president. He asserted, "China has at least as much at stake in the Sino-US